Alex Siebenaler

Honors Reflection 1

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HONR 375

Reflection Essay Intercultural Engagement

What?

I was lucky enough to have a super cool experience of hosting numerous different foreign exchange students in high school. This was super unique to be able to provide a life and opportunity to these students. I had one in 3rd grade, 8th grade, and 10th grade. We were able to host these students from all over Europe, that being Germany, Latvia, as well as the Netherlands.

One of these foreign exchange students, the one from 8th grade, I was able to get really close with, and as a family we got super close with her as well. Her family was very grateful as well, so we were able to make a connection there as well. Laura, the foreign exchange student, was from Latvia and spent a full year with us. She ended up having to leave a little early due to Covid-19 and her trip was cut short. This was super hard, as at this point she was like another sister to me. After this she came back again during my senior year of high school to do an internship with my dad at his workplace. At this point it was like she had never left and we were family again. Her whole family had come to visit us as well, so we built an actual connection with them in person as well. One of my favorite small traditions from that time was that our whole family, Laura included, got matching pajamas for the holidays — it was a small thing, but it made her feel like an actual member of the family rather than a guest passing through.

After this experience, the summer after my freshman year of college, my sister and I were able to go visit Laura in Latvia for over a week and spend time with her family during the biggest holiday for their country, the summer solstice. This was a super cool experience to go live with her for a little bit after she had lived with us multiple times, as well as to be able to experience one of their biggest holidays with them too.

Over the course of time in between seeing each other, our families have kept each other up to date on our lives on a weekly basis, my family has gone to visit other times as well, and we have plans to go there again soon. This experience of building a family with our foreign exchange students has shown me so much about the differences and similarities in cultures and countries and really opened my eyes and showed me the world from a different lens.

We also are very close with one of our other foreign exchange students and are going to be attending her wedding next summer. I was a lot younger when she was here so I was not as close with her, but our families are just as close.

So what?

This experience was so eye-opening to me, I couldn't think of a better way to connect with another culture or be involved with another country besides living there. I was so immersed in her culture and was able to show some of ours as well. Some things that were super fun for us were trying some of her signature dishes, learning some of the language, celebrating some of the different bigger holidays, learning some of their games, as well as so much more from this experience. Specifically holiday-wise, it was super interesting how much we celebrated the summer solstice while we were there. It seemed like the entire country gathered together, regardless of their differences, and celebrated life. There were special drinks for the holiday, and

some dishes. One thing that I thought was interesting was one night when we went out to eat, I ordered baked fish and was expecting an American-style breaded fish and fries, and out came a full fish — skin, eyes, bones, and all — right in front of me. This was true for a lot of the food we were eating, it seemed; the dishes were a lot healthier and more natural. Going along with the food side of things, breakfast was so much more important to them. Breakfast was what fueled the day, whereas here it seems like people just eat something small to start the day. I actually took this aspect and have, ever since then, made breakfast a priority to get good fuel in me for long days and being productive.

What really stood out to me, though, was comparing how the summer solstice was celebrated in the two different places I experienced it. While Laura was living with us, we celebrated it in a pretty low-key, American way — we made a nice dinner, and she talked us through what the holiday meant back home, but it still felt like a regular family dinner with a theme attached to it. I couldn't have imagined what the actual celebration looked like until I was there for it myself. In Latvia, it felt like the entire country shut down for it. We wore leaf hats, which is a traditional part of the holiday, and went to a festival dressed in traditional clothing with Laura's family and friends. There was dancing and singing songs that, as far as I could tell, almost everyone there had grown up knowing. It wasn't a special event put on for us as guests — it was just what the whole community did, together, every year. That contrast taught me something I don't think I really understood before: that the same holiday, even one I thought I already knew because Laura had described it and we'd celebrated a version of it, can look almost unrecognizable depending on where and with whom you experience it. A description, even a loving and detailed one, is not the same as actually being inside the thing itself.

Our culture, being from Minnesota, is similar in many ways. When I was in Latvia for a week, everyone was so wholesome and nice. All Laura's friends were so inviting in teaching me some of their funny lingo and slang while I was there. It seemed to be like this from the very start, after they got over that we were American. I feel like during the times I have been to Europe, the US had been making headlines globally, so that's all anyone thought about Americans, because that's all they saw. I always felt like I was getting judged, but after actually getting to know people, that wall soon dropped. They were telling us some inside jokes and so many other things that really had me and my sister feeling included and at home. Her family was so nice and was always making us food and providing for us. They even took off work to make sure we had things to do and were fed. While we were there, we also went on a little retreat with all her family, family friends, friends, and a whole bunch of people. This kindness was spread by everyone, so you could tell it was wholesome.

As similar as our two cultures felt in a lot of ways, there were real differences too, some obvious and some more subtle. The most obvious one was food — not just the whole fish, but the whole approach to a meal. Food in Latvia felt less processed and more seasonal, built around what was actually available, where in the US I was used to meals being built more around convenience and speed. The other big one was the language gap itself. Even though most of Laura's friends spoke good English, there were constant small moments — a joke that didn't quite translate, a word that only half-made sense, a pause while someone found the right English word — that reminded me I was a guest in someone else's language, not the other way around. Honestly, though, after being in a few different European countries over the years, I've come to think the US and a lot of Western European countries are more similar than different at the broad level — similar values around family, work, and hospitality. The real differences showed up less in the big things and

more in the small, daily details: how meals were structured, how directly people spoke to each other, how holidays were actually lived rather than just marked on a calendar.

I also noticed real similarities between our cultures that went deeper than hospitality. The biggest one is just that everyone is human and has the same basic emotional needs. Laura, even while living in a completely different culture with us, still went out and made her own friends, still missed her parents and her friends back home, still joined activities and tried to build a normal life here rather than just enduring her time with us. Watching her do that showed me that the need for relationships, friendship, and a sense of belonging isn't something that's specific to one culture — it's just part of being a person, and it shows up everywhere, even when the specific customs around it look completely different.

Another thing I want to touch on here is how my understanding had changed over the course of my experiences with Laura, being 8th grade, 12th grade, then the summer going into my 2nd year and 3rd year at college. In 8th grade, I feel like I was very ethnocentric and had never seen the world from a different lens before. When I saw anything different from my way of life, I was quick to judge — this being foods that I saw people eating from other cultures or different lifestyles. It was definitely one of the first times I was truly immersed in another culture and really lived with it every day. After a little bit, I didn't even think about the culture aspect of things because it was fun having another older sister. After the second time Laura came to visit, I feel like it had been so long since I had been immersed at the beginning, I was still a little judgmental of things; however, I was four years older and more mature now at this point. I feel like because of this, I became more curious about learning about the culture rather than just living with someone of the culture. I learned more about the history of Latvia and how it changed after the Soviet era, and how Latvians viewed Americans as a whole. I also devoted more time to

making dishes, like Pīrāgi, which is a bread roll filled with bacon and onion, which was my favorite thing she made. I also tried things I didn't like so much, like dishes with full sardine-type fish. It was especially cool when I got to go visit her as well and connect all the dots and really see the life she grew up in.

Looking back, I think I can trace a lot of that early ethnocentrism to something bigger than just being young. Growing up, I had the same group of friends for most of my childhood, and a lot of that was built around sports — the same teams, the same practices, the same families at the same games. You grow up together, and because of that, you also end up building the same mindset and the same sense of what "normal" looks like, without ever really choosing it or questioning it. I don't think that's unique to me; I think it's pretty common for a lot of people who grow up in a small, not very diverse hometown like mine. Realizing around 8th grade just how much more there was to the world outside that group pushed me to actually go looking for different perspectives instead of waiting for them to show up. In high school, that meant joining clubs that none of my close friends were in, like Peer Helpers and NHS, instead of only doing the activities my existing friend group already did. In college, it's meant putting myself in rooms — classes, clubs, jobs — with people who didn't grow up anything like I did. I don't think I would have gone looking for any of that if Laura hadn't shown me, pretty early on, how small and closed off my version of "normal" actually was.

One of the most memorable moments from all of this didn't actually happen in Latvia — it happened in my hometown, during Laura's second stay with us, senior year. Her parents and brothers flew out to visit her and stayed with us for a while, and for most of them, it was their first time in the United States. Her mother didn't speak any English at all, and the rest of her family spoke a lot less than Laura did, so Laura ended up translating almost everything, all day,

for her own family, in a country that wasn't hers either. It was a strange, interesting thing to watch — our two families trying to actually get to know each other with a language barrier sitting right in the middle of it. Her mom made a dish for us that, if I'm being honest, I was not a big fan of, but I remember her family being so genuinely funny about it, cracking jokes and laughing at themselves, even with almost none of it in English. That stuck with me more than almost anything else from that whole experience. It showed me that connection doesn't actually require a shared language — tone, facial expressions, and just being willing to laugh at yourself in front of strangers can carry a relationship a long way, even when the words themselves can't.

That experience also taught me something about communication and language that I didn't expect. Living with someone who was speaking her second language, I had things come naturally to me that didn't come naturally to her at all — where our dishes went, specific words in a sentence, how certain holidays or routines worked in our house. Laura spoke really well, but there were still real gaps, and there were definitely moments early on where that frustrated me, more than I'm proud to admit. I had to learn to be patient and understanding instead of just getting annoyed when something had to be repeated or explained twice. I had to actively help her find things, understand things, or just be okay with slowing down a conversation instead of talking past the gap. That patience didn't stay in that one relationship, either. In college, living with six roommates who all grew up in different households with different habits around something as small as where dishes go, I noticed I was pulling on that same muscle — reminding myself that just because something feels obvious to me doesn't mean it's obvious to someone else, and that most friction like that comes from different upbringings, not from anyone being wrong.

Now what?

Going forward, I hope to continue to immerse myself in other cultures. Not only this, but I also hope to build genuine and long-lasting connections with other cultures to learn. Not only do I want to continue having this relationship and family orientation with Laura and her family, but I also want to be able to build my web across other cultures and build a connection with others worldwide. I don't want this experience to just be a one-time thing; rather, I want it to be an ongoing thing that I can continue to grow throughout my life, to learn on a more culturally diverse level. My hometown is not very diverse, so I had kind of been in a shell, so to speak, when it came to seeing other cultures. Inviting people into my home and having an in-depth experience of what living in other countries is like, as well as doing that myself, has helped me be more open-minded and find some cool things out about myself as well.

I feel like I can apply this open-mindedness and learning that I have taken from this experience into other areas of my life. In work or social settings, I have already noticed being more curious about other cultures. I have never been very judgmental about other cultures, but now I make it known that I see the other cultures and want to learn about them. In work, friendships, and other aspects of life, I have repeatedly been proactive about learning about people. Similarities or differences don't define a connection whatsoever, so I can apply these things I learned about myself when I travel, being open-minded about places I wouldn't normally think of, or maybe studying abroad myself and fully diving into a different culture from the other side — experiencing it firsthand rather than learning about it from someone else.

Looking at everything I actually took away from this experience, open-mindedness is the biggest one, but it's not the only one. This whole experience is also where my love of travel actually started. Hearing Laura talk about everywhere she had traveled made me want to go see things for myself instead of just hearing about them secondhand, and after her second stay with us ended, I

took one of my first real trips — out to Utah with some friends. I've been hooked on traveling ever since, and I don't think that happens without her pushing me toward it first.

Patience is the other big one. I was never a particularly patient person growing up, but living with someone who was learning a new language and a new culture in real time forced me to slow down and be understanding instead of getting frustrated. I've carried that into college, especially living with six roommates from six different backgrounds, where the small daily friction of shared space gets a lot easier once you assume people are just different, not wrong. And I've carried it into my professional life, too. During an internship with Eide Bailly, I worked on projects with team members based in India, and I found myself pulling directly from what I'd learned living with Laura — being aware that English might be someone's second language, being conscious of time zone gaps, and being more direct and clear in how I communicated instead of assuming context that wasn't there. That experience with Laura gave me a head start on something a lot of my peers were running into for the first time in that internship.

I want to keep looking for opportunities like this going forward — not just the big, obvious ones like studying abroad, but the small, everyday ones too: a new roommate, a new coworker, a new classmate from somewhere I've never been. This experience taught me that the biggest shifts in how I see the world didn't come from one trip. They came from staying close to the same people, in both directions, over years.